

The Trust Surface

Five things a Japanese buyer checks **before** they will consider your offer at all — and why your conversion work never reaches them.

1	Is this seller real?	disclosure
2	Can I pay my way?	payment breadth
3	When exactly does it arrive?	delivery
4	What if it's wrong?	returns
5	Who answers, and when?	support

There are two passes. Your page is built for the second one.

Western landing pages are engineered for an **evaluation pass**: is this good, is this worth it, is this better than the alternative. Every tool you own — the headline test, the social proof, the offer — operates there.

Japanese consumers tend to run a **risk-elimination pass first**. Not "is this good," but "is there a reason not to." It is fast, it is mostly unconscious, and it happens before any of your persuasion is read.

WHY THE TRANSLATED SITE DIDN'T WORK

A single unresolved item in the first pass ends the visit. Your conversion work is not underperforming — it is **never being executed**. Adding more benefit copy to a page that fails the risk pass changes nothing, which is exactly the result most teams report.

1 Is this seller real?

Japan expects consumer sellers to publish a formal commercial disclosure. Buyers know to look for it.

- Legal seller name, a physical address, and a contactable phone number
- Price, additional charges, payment timing, and delivery timing
- Returns and cancellation terms
- The name of the person responsible

THE PART THAT SURPRISES OVERSEAS TEAMS

Its absence is not neutral. A Japanese shopper who goes looking for this page and cannot find it has not learned "this store is incomplete" — they have learned "**this store is hiding something.**" No amount of design quality overrides that inference.

ALSO

A return address outside Japan is checked before purchase, not after. It changes the perceived cost of being wrong from a stamp to an international parcel.

2

CHECK TWO

Can I pay the way I pay?

Japan sustains many payment methods in parallel. Card-only checkout is a narrower door than it looks from abroad.

- Convenience-store payment, still used by buyers who will not put a card online
- Carrier billing, code payments, bank transfer, cash on delivery
- Each has a demographic attached to it, and they do not overlap neatly

THE QUESTION THAT MATTERS

It is not "which method is largest." It is "**is the method this particular buyer uses present.**" A buyer whose method is missing does not switch to yours. They close the tab, and you record it as a pricing objection.

WHY THIS ONE IS SLOW

Payment breadth is the only item on this list that needs a provider decision and integration work. Start it before the others, and finish it last.

3

CHECK THREE

When exactly does it arrive?

"3–5 business days" is a range. Japanese buyers are accustomed to a date.

Domestic Japanese commerce has trained buyers to expect precision: a named delivery date, frequently a chosen time window, and a tracking number that appears when promised. Against that baseline a range does not read as honest estimation.

WHAT A RANGE COMMUNICATES

A range says the seller has kept the flexibility and given the buyer the uncertainty. That is the same shape as every other item in the risk pass — and the buyer resolves it the same way, by leaving.

IF YOU GENUINELY CANNOT PROMISE A DATE

Say so plainly, with the reason and the worst case. A stated worst case is trusted. A vague best case is not.

4 CHECK FOUR What if it's wrong?

Japan has no cooling-off period for online sales. Most overseas sellers hear that and relax.

It is true that mail-order and online sales sit outside the cooling-off rules that cover door-to-door selling. But there is a second rule that almost never appears in English.

THE DEFAULT NOBODY TOLD YOU ABOUT

If your store does not clearly display a return policy, the law supplies one: the buyer may return within **8 days of receipt**, paying return shipping. The absence of a policy does not mean no returns. It means the default applies — and it is not the one you wrote.

WHERE THIS ACTUALLY BITES

An English returns page that isn't linked from the Japanese checkout, or a policy buried in global terms, produces the same outcome as having none: the policy operating in your store is not yours.

5

CHECK FIVE

Who answers, and when?

Support hours are part of the product in Japan, not part of the operations budget.

- Stated hours in JST, on the page, before purchase
- A contact route that is not only a form with no acknowledgement
- Replies in Japanese — competent, not necessarily elegant

THE TIMEZONE TRAP

"We reply within 24 hours" measured from your office means a Japanese buyer sleeps twice before hearing from you. The promise you published and the experience they had are different products, and only one of them generates the review.

MINIMUM VIABLE

You do not need a Japanese team on day one. You need a stated, honest window that you actually hit, and an acknowledgement that arrives immediately.

This isn't caution. It's a different default about who carries risk.

It is tempting to file all of this under "Japanese consumers are demanding." That framing is comfortable and it stops you from fixing anything.

A more useful reading: in a market with strong seller-side disclosure norms, unresolved ambiguity is understood as the seller keeping optionality and handing the buyer the uncertainty.

WHY MORE BENEFITS DON'T HELP

Your page is not being judged as unpersuasive. It is being read as **asking the buyer to absorb risk the seller should have absorbed**. No headline fixes that, because it is not an argument the buyer is having with your copy.

The twelve-question audit

- | | |
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| ☐ A commercial disclosure page exists and is linked from checkout | ☐ A physical address in Japan appears on it |
| ☐ A reachable phone number appears on it | ☐ The responsible person is named |
| ☐ At least one non-card payment method is offered | ☐ Payment options are visible before the final step |
| ☐ Delivery is stated as a date, not a range | ☐ A tracking number is promised and actually sent |
| ☐ The return policy is in Japanese, before purchase | ☐ Who pays return shipping is stated explicitly |
| ☐ A return address inside Japan is given | ☐ Support hours are stated in JST and are met |

SCORING

Any unticked box is a place the risk pass can stop. They do not average out — a single unresolved item is sufficient on its own.

The order to fix them in

ITEM	EFFORT	BLOCKS
Commercial disclosure page	About a day	Legitimacy. Everything else
Return policy, stated	About a day	The statutory default applying instead of yours
Delivery specificity	Days	Depends on your logistics answer
Support hours in JST	Days	A staffing decision, not a build
Payment breadth	Weeks	Provider selection and integration

NOTE THE SHAPE

The two cheapest items gate the most. Teams start with the payment integration because it feels substantial, and launch with the cheap ones still missing.

When to wait

The trust surface is cheap to build and expensive to fake. Two situations where I would delay a Japanese consumer launch rather than patch it:

- **You cannot yet accept a return inside Japan.**
Every other item can be honestly stated at a modest level. This one cannot — and a return experience that goes wrong in month two produces public reviews that outlive the fix.
- **Nobody can answer a Japanese email within one business day.**
Not fluently. Reliably. Without that, the trust surface leaks faster than acquisition spend can fill it, and you will conclude the market is weak.

WHY THIS MATTERS MORE HERE

A poor first launch does not just cost the launch. It teaches your own organisation that Japan does not work — and that belief tends to outlive everyone who was in the room when it formed.

Nothing on this list is difficult. All of it is invisible from outside Japan.

That is the actual problem with selling into Japan. It is not a hard market. It is an **unlisted** one — and teams discover the list in month four, from the first return request, or from a quarter of traffic that never converted and never explained why.

Run the twelve questions on your own store.
Tell me which one you failed — I'll tell you
what it's costing.

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